

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

Maria Garcia-Osipenko

My earliest inspiration to teach came from my grandmother, a devoted biology teacher whose enthusiasm for her students and subject was contagious. She taught me that learning is a lifelong journey of curiosity and discovery, a principle that continues to guide my own approach to teaching. My passion for teaching deepened through my own educational experiences. As an undergraduate, I was fortunate to learn from professors who were deeply engaged and encouraged me to pursue a career in academia. Later, at Arizona State University, my advisors further strengthened my commitment to both research and teaching, helping me refine my research questions and develop the skills necessary to conduct independent research. These experiences have convinced me that great teaching is transformative; it can spark intellectual curiosity, shape students' paths, and inspire innovative research.

During graduate school, I gained valuable teaching experience and developed my own perspective on effective instruction. I independently designed and taught my own course, *Microeconomic Principles*, and served as a teaching assistant for *Public Economics*, *Industrial Organization*, *Environmental Economics*, *Business Statistics*, and *Macroeconomic Principles*.

Teaching Philosophy and Course Design — My teaching philosophy centers on developing both the economic intuition and the analytical reasoning of my students. I believe that economic education should bridge the gap between theory and practice, helping students understand how economic models explain real-world behavior. In my classroom, I strive to create an environment that is both structured and engaging, where students are encouraged to think critically, ask questions, and apply concepts to real-world issues.

In my *Microeconomic Principles* course, I designed lectures that combined clear structure with active learning. Each class began with a short quiz to assess comprehension from the previous session, followed by a discussion of correct answers and explanations. This routine helped reinforce key concepts while allowing me to identify and address common misunderstandings. To bring theoretical concepts to life, I incorporated real-world case studies, short games, and data-driven examples illustrating core economic ideas. For instance, when introducing the concept of externalities, I connected it to my research on electric vehicles and solar panels. I explained that both technologies mitigate negative externalities associated with carbon emissions and air pollution, providing an economic rationale for government subsidies. We then discussed how economists determine the optimal level of subsidies. This example helped students understand how economic tools can inform policy design. To demonstrate how economic reasoning extends beyond academia, I invited a guest speaker from Google to discuss how microeconomic thinking informs business decisions. Students noted in their evaluations that “*connections to real-life applications*” and “*practice quizzes with answer review*” were among the most valuable aspects of the course. These comments reaffirm my belief that engagement and relevance are central to effective teaching. Student feedback also emphasized that “*all of the practice problems and lectures were organized and presented very well*”, further confirming that the structured yet interactive design of my lectures effectively supports learning.

Engaging Diverse Learners — As a teaching assistant for multiple courses, I worked with over 1,100 students, focusing on creating an inclusive and supportive environment where everyone felt comfortable engaging with the material and asking questions. My teaching experience at Arizona State University has uniquely prepared me to work with a broad and diverse student body. ASU's mission to be known for who it includes rather than who it excludes creates a learning environment with students from a wide range of backgrounds and levels of preparation, many of whom balance their academic work with professional and family commitments. I encouraged open discussion and designed activities that ensured every student had an opportunity to engage meaningfully with the material. I guided students through questions that prompted them to explain their reasoning and work toward solutions on their own, helping them develop confidence and independence in their learning. I also strive to provide all students with the tools they need to succeed by offering generous office hours, accommodating meetings online or in person, and providing timely,

constructive feedback. I emphasize fairness and transparency by clearly communicating grading criteria and offering individualized guidance to students who need additional support. In my view, accessibility and equity are essential components of impactful teaching.

Reflection and Continuous Improvement — I constantly strive to improve and incorporate student feedback. As an instructor, I distributed anonymous mid-semester evaluation forms that asked for feedback on the pace, clarity, and difficulty of the course, as well as suggestions for improvement. This practice has been valuable in helping me adapt my teaching to students' needs in real time. I also reached out to those who appear to be struggling after exams or assignments to offer additional guidance. I believe that students learn best when they feel comfortable asking questions and when they know their input is genuinely valued.

Integrating Research and Teaching — I view good teaching and productive research as mutually reinforcing activities that advance my professional growth. Revisiting fundamental concepts at the undergraduate and graduate levels helps me see familiar topics in new ways and identify sharper research questions. Preparing material so that it is accessible to students also pushes me to deepen my own understanding, think more critically about how theory connects to evidence, and communicate complex ideas with clarity. In turn, my research experience deepens my expertise in the subject and allows me to bring cutting-edge methods and relevant research findings into the classroom.

In my future teaching, I intend to build on the connection between research and teaching to design courses that expose students to the process of economic research. In upper-division undergraduate and graduate courses, I would integrate recent research papers to help students engage directly with ongoing developments in the field. For example, when introducing new tools and models, I would draw on research papers that demonstrate how these frameworks are applied to real-world economic problems. I also plan to give students the opportunity to select papers that align with their interests, present them to the class, and lead discussions on their contributions and limitations. This approach fosters deeper engagement as students analyze empirical strategies, evaluate underlying assumptions, and recognize each paper's contribution to the field.

Using AI to Enhance Pedagogy — I aim to continue developing my teaching practice to prepare students for a rapidly changing, data-driven world. I am particularly interested in exploring innovative teaching approaches that leverage AI to enhance students' learning. I believe that productive struggle is essential to mastering critical thinking and problem-solving skills, and I worry that the unreflective use of AI tools may weaken students' ability to develop those skills. At the same time, AI holds enormous potential to enhance teaching and learning. As educators, our task is to guide students to use AI as a tool that augments their abilities rather than replaces them. For example, one approach I plan to implement is the flipped classroom model, where students review lecture videos before class and use in-person sessions for active learning, collaborative problem-solving, and discussions. This structure encourages independent reasoning while maintaining limits on AI use. I also view it as essential to integrate AI into assignments in a deliberate and transparent manner. By providing clear guidance on its appropriate use and emphasizing academic integrity, students can learn to recognize both the value and limitations of these tools. For example, in upper-division courses, I would integrate at-home coding exercises, recognizing that AI tools have lowered the barrier to entry for programming. To ensure genuine understanding, however, I will incorporate graded in-class assessments that require students to explain the underlying economic models, interpret code output, and articulate the logic of specific coding steps. This approach both strengthens students' conceptual understanding and fosters responsible, reflective use of emerging technologies.

My teaching and research background equip me to teach a broad array of courses at both the undergraduate and graduate levels. These include *Principles of Microeconomics*, *Intermediate Microeconomics*, *Environmental Economics*, *Industrial Organization*, *Public Economics*, *Statistics*, and *Econometrics* at the undergraduate level, and *Environmental and Energy Economics*, *Industrial Organization*, and *Econometrics* at the graduate level, as well as other related courses in applied microeconomics. I look forward to continuing to grow as an instructor and to contributing to a diverse range of courses.